



SALARY GUIDE 2026

Accounting & Finance

What accounting and finance people are asking to be paid, why they're looking, where they'll work, and how to hire them before you need them.

\$95K

Typical ask for a Senior Accountant

46%

Are looking for growth or a next step

2%

Named pay as the reason they're looking

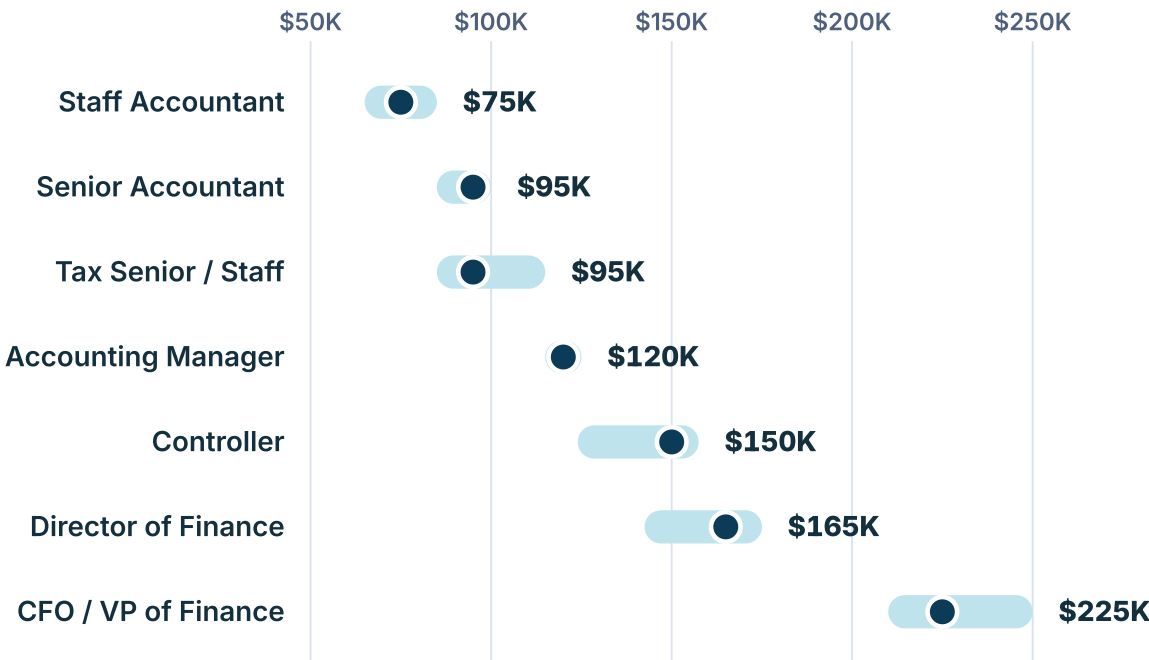
8%

Will only work remote

Built from 612 Staff Financial Group and NorthPoint Search Group candidate questionnaires and job applications (Aug-Sep 2026) and U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics data.

What they're asking to be paid

Desired base salary, from 165 candidates who told us what they want in their next role.
The bar is the middle half of answers. The dot is the typical ask (the median).



TITLE	ANSWERS	MIDDLE HALF	TYPICAL ASK	LOWEST THEY'D TAKE
Staff Accountant	27	\$65K – \$85K	\$75K	\$66.5K
Senior Accountant	29	\$85K – \$100K	\$95K	\$92.5K
Tax Senior / Staff	26	\$85K – \$115K	\$95K	—
Accounting Manager / Supervisor	15	\$115K – \$125K	\$120K	\$110K
Controller	14	\$124K – \$157.5K	\$150K	\$150K
Director of Finance / Accounting	7	\$142.5K – \$175K	\$165K	\$150K
CFO / VP of Finance	47	\$210K – \$250K	\$225K	\$210K

The lowest salary people say they'd accept sits close to what they ask for. A Senior Accountant asking \$95K says the floor is about \$92.5K. There isn't much room to come in low.

Government numbers for comparison

Median annual pay, metro Atlanta, May 2025 (BLS). These include every experience level, so they run lower than what experienced candidates ask for.

Financial managers (controllers, finance directors)	\$171,240
Financial and investment analysts	\$100,830
Accountants and auditors	\$85,820
Payroll and timekeeping clerks	\$62,710
Bookkeeping, accounting and auditing clerks	\$51,170

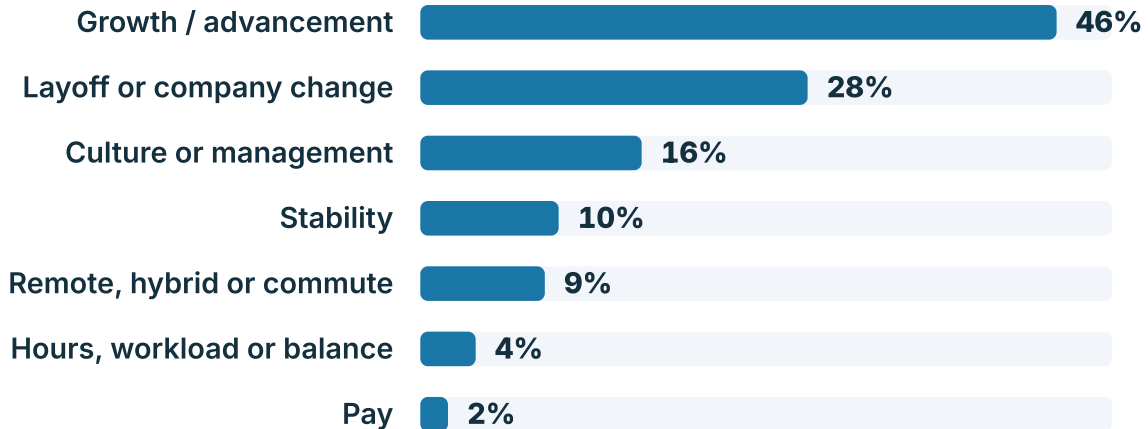
How to read this

Asking pay is base salary only, before bonus and benefits. Titles with fewer than 5 answers aren't shown. About 39% of candidates who gave a location are in Georgia; the rest are spread across the U.S.

WHY THEY MOVE

Growth beats pay

Why they're looking, from 201 candidates who answered in their own words. Many gave more than one reason, so the bars add up to more than 100%.

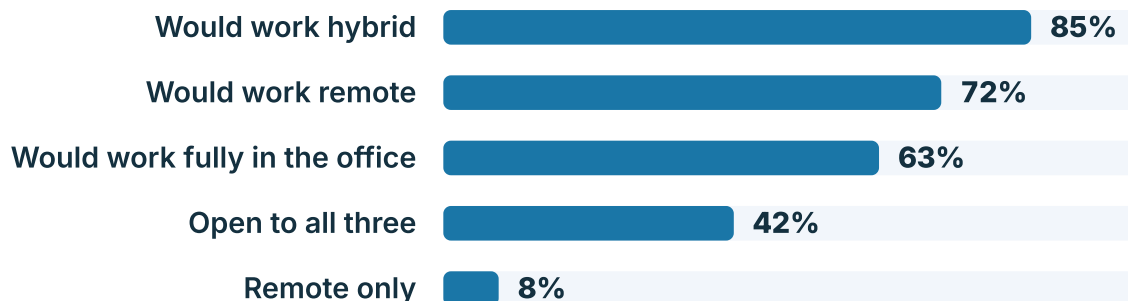


46% are looking for growth or a next step. Only 2% named pay. 28% are on the market because of a layoff or a change at their company, so good people are available right now.

WHERE THEY'LL WORK

Hybrid works for almost everyone

From 236 candidates. They could pick every setup they'd accept.

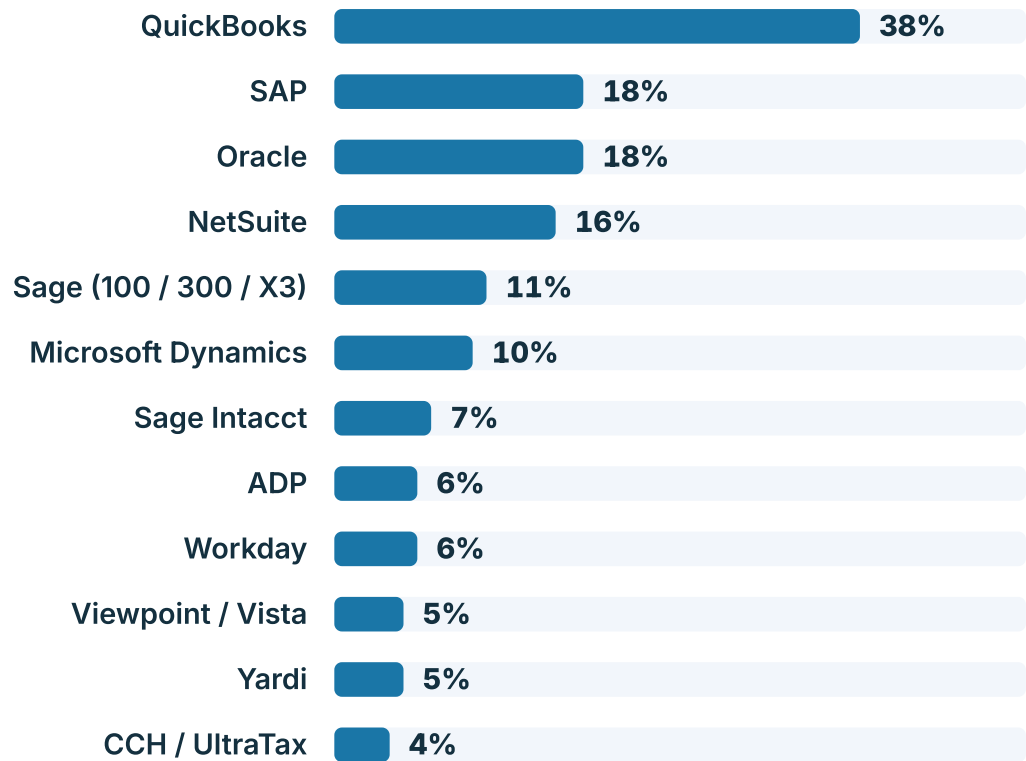


85% would work hybrid and 63% would work fully in the office. Only 8% will only work remote. You don't need a fully remote job to compete.

SYSTEMS

The software they know

Accounting and payroll systems named by 141 candidates. Many know more than one.



QuickBooks is the most common. If you run SAP, Oracle or NetSuite, ask about it in your screening questions. About 1 in 6 candidates knows each one.

TURNOVER

How often finance people leave

Departures per 100 jobs in a year (all separations, 2025), from the BLS Job Openings and Labor Turnover Survey.



How long people stay

Median years with their current employer, January 2026 (BLS).

Management (incl. controllers, CFOs)	6.1 years
Business and financial operations (incl. accountants)	4.6 years
Office and administrative support (incl. AP, payroll, bookkeeping)	4.1 years
All occupations	4.1 years

What that means for a team of 10

At professional-services turnover, a 10-person accounting team sees about 5 or 6 departures a year. In finance and insurance it's about 2 or 3. Either way, most of those openings are predictable.

A year is 12 times the average monthly rate. It counts departures, so one seat can turn over more than once.

WHAT TO DO

Five ways to hire better this year

1. Price to the ask.

Put the middle-half range for the role in your job post. Candidates' floor is close to their ask, so low offers lose people.

2. Sell the path, not just the pay.

46% are looking for growth. Show the next title, who they'll learn from, and what they'll own.

3. Offer hybrid.

85% will work hybrid. Only 8% insist on remote.

4. Screen for your system.

Ask about your ERP up front. Train the rest.

5. Build the bench before you need it.

Turnover is predictable. Keep a short list of ready people behind every seat so the next resignation is a phone call, not a crisis.

Accounting and finance recruiting, done for you.

For every search, Staff Financial Group builds a custom screening questionnaire with you, so every résumé arrives with your questions already answered. Candidates can add a short video intro. Direct hires come with a replacement guarantee, and we can payroll contract hires for you.

Start a search → stafffinancial.com

METHOD AND SOURCES

Pay, reasons, work setup and software come from screening questionnaires and job applications that candidates completed for Staff Financial Group and NorthPoint Search Group between 2026-08-11 and 2026-09-30: 612 people, newest form per person. Pay figures are desired base salary for the titles shown; the middle half is the 25th to 75th percentile, rounded to \$500. Groups with fewer than 5 answers are left out, and no individual answer is shown.

- BLS Job Openings and Labor Turnover Survey, 2025 annual averages (released March 13, 2026), Tables 20 and 22.
- BLS Employee Tenure, median years with current employer by occupation, January 2026, Table 6.
- BLS Occupational Employment and Wage Statistics, May 2025, Atlanta-Sandy Springs-Roswell, GA.